

Alabama Learning Hour

Ava at the Farm! Talking about Yourself, and Possession

March 3rd, 2026

1 *Ava innaasi iyyi ostaakaha* Text

Ava innaasi iyyi ostaakaha

Ava's animals - Alabama Text

naasi iyyi ostaaka ava imiisafa lahwahchi.
iisahayon kati lochan, ifa hatkak iisahchi.
achan akaakak taftaapin, aayampo kolokbifan fatak nampobi.
ya fatak laanahchi, ahki fatak okchakkohchi.
chassi imiisafan chichobon hiichali?
oh, waakoolo.
Avak hachonchoban bannati, maamin taatak waakan choopati.
ittofan sawak wiikahchi.
sawak Avan imbiniilihchi.
stanooko!

Ava's animals - English translation

There are a lot of animals at Ava's home.
In the house, a black cat and a white dog live.
Outside, there are five chickens, and in the bowl, there are many fish.
This fish is yellow, that fish is green.
Do I see a horse in the barn?
No, it is a cow.
Ava wanted an aligator, but dad bought a cow.
In a tree, the raccoon lives.
The raccoon visits Ava.
the end!

2 Vocabulary

Nouns

naasi iyyi ostaaka	animal
iisa	house
kati	cat
ifa	dog
akaaka	chicken
aayampo	dish
kolokbi	deep hole
aayampo kolokbi	bowl
ḥaḥo	fish
chassi iisa	barn
chassi	corn
chichoba	horse
waaki	cow
hachonchoba	alligator
hachi	tail
choba	big
taata	dad
itto	tree
sawa	raccoon

Verbs

lahwa	to be many, a lot
nampo	to be many
iisa	to live at a place
hiicha	to see
banna	to want
choopa	to buy
wiika	to stay, be, live
imbiniili	to visit
anooka	to be gone, finished up

Adjectives

locha	black
hatka	white
laana	yellow
okchakko	green

Other

acha	outside
taŋŋaapi	five
ya	this
ahki	that
maamin	but, however
stanooko	the end

3 Review

- Here are some topics in the text which we have encountered in previous weeks.

3.1 Tense on Verbs

Stative *o/bi* Easy Recipe – One noun

(1) **Statement - *o* ending**

[**Subject** + **k**] [Verb + **-bi**].

Ava-k kanno-**bi**.

‘Ava is good’.

(2) **Statement - *a, i* ending**

[**Subject** + **k**] [Verb + **-o**]?

Ava-k ayokp-**o**?

‘Ava is happy’

- Add *-k* to the ‘Subject’ of the action.
- If you’re making a statement about someone’s state, and the verb ends in an *o*, add *-bi* to the verb.
- If you’re making a statement about someone’s state, and the verb ends in an *a* or *i*, replace it with *o*
- Put the Subject first, then the Verb—and you’re done!

★Q: *hoyapli* means ‘tired’. How would I say “Ava is tired”?

Progressive -hchi Easy Recipe – One noun

(3) Statement

[**Subject** + **k**] [Verb + **-hchi**].

Ava-k bitli-**hchi**.

‘Ava is dancing’.

- Add *-k* to the ‘Subject’ of the action.
- If you’re making a statement about someone doing an action right now, add *-hchi* to the verb.
- Put the Subject first, then the Verb—*and you’re done!*

★Q: *choffi* means ‘to jump’. How would I say “Ava is jumping”?

Past tense -ti Easy Recipe – One noun

(4) Statement

[**Subject** + **k**] [Verb + **-ti**].

Ava-k bitli-**ti**.

‘Ava danced’.

- Add *-k* to the ‘Subject’ of the action.
- If you’re making a statement about someone doing an action in the past, add *-ti* to the verb.
- Put the Subject first, then the Verb—*and you’re done!*

★Q: *chiyali* means ‘to walk’. How would I say “Ava walked”?

- These endings (*o/bi*, *-hchi*, *ti*) are pieces on the *verb* to talk about when the action occurred.

Remember! The tense recipes here are only talking about *statements*. To ask a question, we need to use a different ending. See the previous handouts for more information.

3.2 Case on Nouns

- So far, we’ve talked about pieces that go on verbs. Now let’s look at pieces that go on nouns.

- Last week we spoke about about one of these noun pieces: *case*.
- Case tells us the role of the noun in the sentence: who is doing what to whom.
- The **k** tells us it is the **subject** of the sentence. For now, we can think of the subject as the noun which the sentence is “about”.
- For example, the noun in agent verbs marked with this **k**.

– *Avak bitliti* “Ava danced”, *anok chiyahliliti* “I walked”

Watch out! We will have to adjust this definition of a subject in future lessons, but this is a way to think about them for now.

- Case morphemes which indicate the subject, like **k**, are known as **nominative case**.

★ **Important!** In Alabama, the subject can be an agent or a patient.

- That is, the subject of an **agent** verb is an agent, and is marked with nominative case **k**.

– **Avak choffihchi** “Ava is jumping”

- The subject of a **patient** verb is a patient, and is marked with nominative case **k**.

– **Avak sookahchi** “Ava is being held”

- Both agent and patient subjects use the same **-k** ending. That’s because both are subjects, even though one is doing the action and one is being affected.

★ What about situations where there is more than one noun?

– These types of verbs are very common. They are called **transitive verbs**.

– *I saw him, I helped you*

- If there is an **agent** who is *doing something* to another noun, then the agent is marked with **nominative case, k**.
- The noun that is being **affected** by the subject is marked with **oblique case, n**.

4 More on Nouns

4.1 Nominal Conjunction

- Sometimes we want to talk about *two nouns together*.
- For example: *Ava and Jacob danced*. In English, we use the word *and*.
- In Alabama, we do this by adding a small piece to the **first noun**: *-n*.
- Then, we add the case markers as we learnt last week!

Nominal Conjunction Easy Recipe – Two nouns

(5) Nominal Conjunction in Subject Position

[**First Noun** + **-n**] [**Second Noun** + **-k**] [**Verb** + **-tense**]

Ava-n Jacob-k bitli-ti.

‘Ava and Jacob danced’.

(6) Nominal Conjunction in Object Position

[**Noun(s)** + **-k**] [**First Noun** + **-n**] [**Second Noun** + **-k**] [**Verb** + **-tense**]

Ava-k Jacob-n Tanyan hiicha-ti.

‘Ava saw Jacob and Tanya’.

- If you have two nouns together, add *-n* to the **first noun**.
- Add the correct case to the **second noun** (*-k* if it is the subject of the sentence, *-n* if it is the object).
- Then add the correct tense ending to the verb.

Let’s practice! How would you say this in Alabama? Recall: *choffi* “to jump”, *chiyal* “to walk”, *bitli* “to dance”, *hiicha* “to see”, *choopa* “to buy”

- (7)
- a. Ava and Jacob danced
 - b. Maxine and Jacob walked
 - c. Jacob and Tanya jumped
 - d. Jacob saw Maxine and Ava
 - e. Ava bought a cow (*waaki*) and a racoon (*sawa*)

4.2 Nouns, Adjectives, and Plurals

- When we talk about nouns, we may want to add extra descriptions to them
- For example, if I wanted to talk about different descriptions of cats in English, I could talk about a *black cat* or *white cat*
- This “description” word is called an *adjective*
- In English, the adjective goes before the noun
- But in Alabama, the adjective appears *after* the noun!

– *kati locha* “black cat”

★Q: How would you say “white cat”? What about “green fish”?

- If we want to use a noun and adjective in a sentence, we need to remember to use *case*
- When there is an adjective, the case marker appears on the *adjective*, and not the noun.

– *Avak ifa lochan hiichati* “Ava saw a black dog”

- Sometimes we may also want to talk about *more than one thing*. For example, maybe Ava saw multiple *dogs*.
- This is called *plural* marking
- In English, we typically use the *-s* ending to make it plural.
- In Alabama, we use the ending *-ha* at the end of a noun

– *Avak ifahan hiichati* “Ava saw dogs”

★ *Important!* In English, we can add the plural *-s* ending to most nouns.

- There are differences in Alabama, as to whether we add the *-ha* ending to nouns. Some speakers only add *-ha* *animate* nouns (e.g. animals). For other speakers, *inanimate* nouns can also add *-ha* (e.g. chairs)
- Ask your family what they do! In this lesson, we will add plural endings to animals, which is the common type of noun to allow the *-ha* ending

Who saw what? Let's practice with a partner! *Using the list of adjectives and nouns, ask your partner “What did Ava see?” or “What saw Ava”? Your partner should respond with a type of animal! Make sure to use the full sentence in your response, with the case markers.*

(8) Example:

Q: *Avak naason hiichahchō?*

A: *Avak kati lochan hiichati*

(9) Example:

Q: *naasok Avan hiichahchō?*

A: *ifa hatkak Avan hiichati*

Adjectives

- **locha** ‘black’
- **laana** ‘yellow’
- **hatka** ‘white’
- **okchakko** ‘green’

Nouns

- **kati** ‘cat’
- **chichoba** ‘horse’
- **ifa** ‘dog’
- **waaki** ‘cow’
- **akaaka** ‘chicken’
- **hachonchoba** ‘alligator’
- **łalo** ‘fish’
- **sawa** ‘raccoon’

4.3 Am-Possession

- When we talk about nouns, we may also want to talk about *possession*
 - e.g. *my cat, your cat*
- To talk about *possession*, nouns can “combine” with other nouns to describe the individual who owns, possesses it—the individual that the noun

belongs to.

(10) **Possessors**

are arguments of nouns that describe individuals who are related to the noun by the possession/ownership/belonging relationship.

(11) **Possessee**

the thing or individual being had, owned, possessed is called **Possessee**.

(12) my friend
POSSESSOR POSSESSEE

(13) am + okla
my + friend
POSSESSOR + POSSESSEE

- In Alabama, nouns differ in how their possessors are expressed! Consider ‘my friend’ vs. ‘my name’:

(14) am + okla
my + friend
POSSESSOR

(15) cha + holchifa
my + name
POSSESSOR

- Today we will talk about *am*-Possessors, or Possessors II, which the majority of nouns use. We will save *cha*-Possessors for later.

Cha-Possessors (Possessors I) are sometimes called in the literature **inalienable** Possessors, meaning that they are inseparable from the individual that they own.

Am-Possessors (Possessors II) are sometimes called **alienable** Possessors, indicating that relationship between them and the noun is more free.

Possessives II Easy Recipe

[**Possessor** + **Noun** + **Case**]

Possessor Morphemes:

	Singular	Plural	
1	am- ‘my’	kom-/pom- ‘our’	<i>1st person = speaker</i>
2	chim- ‘your’	hachim- ‘y’all’s’	<i>2nd person = addressee</i>
3	noun (e.g. Ava)	noun (e.g. children)	<i>3rd person = someone else</i>

- (16)
- a. **am-** + **okla** = *amokla* ‘my friend’
 - b. **chim-** + **okla** = *chimokla* ‘your friend’
 - c. **Ava** + **okla** = *Ava okla* ‘Ava’s friend’
 - d. **kom-/pom** + **okla** = *komokla* or *pomokla* ‘our friend’
 - e. **hachim-** + **okla** = *hachimokla* ‘ya’ll’s friend’
 - f. **poskoha** + **okla** = *poskoha okla* ‘children’s friend’

Verbs

- **afaaka** ‘to laugh’
 - **isko** ‘to drink’
 - **bitli** ‘to dance’
- **chiyahli** ‘to walk’
 - **ilakomayli** ‘to swim’
 - **choffi** ‘to jump’

Let’s practice! Using the verbs we covered a couple of weeks ago, translate the following into Alabama! Remember to pay attention to the tense and plural markers

kati ‘cat’

- (17)
- a. my cat is jumping
 - b. your cats danced
 - c. Ava’s cat is walking

ifa ‘dog’

- (18)
- a. our dogs laughed
 - b. ya’ll’s dog swam
 - c. the children’s dog is drinking

ʔaʔo ‘fish’

hachonchoba ‘alligator’

- (19)
- a. my fish is swimming
 - b. your fish danced
 - c. Ava’s fish swam

- (20)
- a. our alligator laughed
 - b. y’all’s alligators walked
 - c. the children’s alligators are dancing

5 Talking about myself: *What did I do yesterday?*

- So far, we have been using verbs to talk about what *someone else* is doing.
- Of course, we can use verbs to talk about more situations: what *I* have done, what *you* have done, what *we* have done, and what *ya’ll* have done.
- The remaining session will focus on how Alabama changes its verb to talk about what *I* have done. We have covered a lot today, so we will discuss the other situations another time.
- In many languages, verbs tell us who their arguments are. Consider:

(21) I dance. I am happy.

(22) Ava dancess. Ava is happy.

- This process is called **agreement**. The verb *agrees* with the subject in English, and shows us what kind of an individual it refers to.
- Agreement on the verb also appears in Alabama.
- To talk about myself, you need to **add -li** between the verb and the tense marker.

Agent Verb Sentence in Past Tense -ti/hchō Easy Recipe for “I”

(23) **Statement**

[(**anok**)] [Verb + **-li** + **-ti**].

(Anok) bitli-**li**-ti. Piyaaka (anok) bitli-**li**-ti.

‘I danced’. ‘Yesterday I danced’.

(24) **Question**

[(**anok**)] [Verb + **-li** + **-hchō**]?

(Anok) bitli-**li**-hchō? Piyaaka (anok) bitli-**li**-hchō?

‘Did I dance?’ ‘Did I dance yesterday’?

- When the subject of a sentence is a speaker (‘I’), we can use the word *anok*.
- Unlike in English, using the subject is optional in Alabama when it refers to the speaker
 - The *-li* on the verb tells us it is “I” who is doing the action!

Let’s recall what “I” did yesterday! *How would you say this in Alabama?*

- (25) Q: Did I laugh yesterday?
A: Yes, I laughed yesterday.
- (26) Q: Did I dance yesterday?
A: Yes, I danced yesterday.
- (27) Q: Did I walk yesterday?
A: Yes, I walked.
- (28) Q: Did I drink yesterday?
A: Yes, I drank.
- (29) Q: Did I jump yesterday?
A: Yes, I jumped yesterday.
- (30) Q: Did I swim yesterday?
A: Yes, I swam yesterday.

Verbs

- **afaaka** ‘to laugh’
- **isko** ‘to drink’
- **bitli** ‘to dance’
- **chiyahli** ‘to walk’
- **ilakomayli** ‘to swim’
- **choffi** ‘to jump’